Read/listen to the article by Hutson (2021) in Nature on Robo-writers. This week, post your thoughts on the risks and benefits of the use AI writers at different levels, from administrative work to creative writing.
You should demonstrate that you understand the topic covered and ensure you use references to academic literature (journals, books, reports, etc.).

Learning Outcomes

- Apply and critically appraise machine learning techniques to real-world problems, particularly where technical risk and uncertainty is involved.

Initial Post

The benefits of using AI writers at different levels vary according to context, in my view. For simple administrative tasks – e.g. generating a simple set of clear and unambiguous instructions for a task - can be done quickly with an AI prompt, as opposed to spending time carefully considering what words to use and how to phrase something. AI can advise me on my grammar and spelling, as MS Word has done for decades, but it can also review my words in context and advise on tone and clarity. These are all things I can do for myself, but where the output is more important than the process, such as in the example I gave above, I'd prefer to spend less time on writing the text and just a short time on editing what AI has suggested.

However, it's clear when a colleague uses AI to generate a simple email as the feel of the text, the "voice" is different. The risk here is that people become incapable of vocalising their thoughts and choosing the right words without assistance. It's also a risk that people will accept whatever is generated by AI, without properly checking it.

Once we move into the realms of more complex thoughts and communications, the danger of losing the human "voice" is even greater. Will the next William Shakespeare simply be the person who came up with the best AI prompt? Will original thought be lost if AI becomes our source of art and literature? Or will AI be able to make leaps of imagination that are beyond the human brain because it has greater experience than any individual and is less constrained by reality?

More specifically, the risks of using AI for writing – be it in simple emails or great works of literature – are that the large language models are a product of their experiences. Just like a person who follows only people who share their own beliefs on social media, the view of AI is coloured by its experience which is not necessarily fully rounded. Hutson (2021) speaks of the dangers of AI having access to both extreme and outdated views and bringing those into its responses as if they are facts. For example, a nurse is assumed to be female.

There is a great dilemma here. We can restrict the data available to AI models so that they don't ingest any prejudiced material. This could lead to the question of whether truly unbiased data even exists. We could ensure that AI receives conflicting data that could enable it to always present a balanced view, but can it be trained to fully provide all viewpoints, rather than the most likely or popular viewpoint?

Part of the problem is that AI responses to prompts currently produce plausible, sensible responses, which can be completely incorrect. (Wachter *et al*., 2024) There is no duty on the LLM to speak only the truth. Its responses are produced using probability, rather than purely genuine research. LLMs speak to us with the authority of an encyclopaedia, making it appear inherently trustworthy. It's a great tool, but we must learn to review, edit and fact-check. Of

course, when every internet search produces an AI response, it becomes harder to fully fact-check and, as humans are always looking for the easiest path, I suspect that due diligence will become a rarity restricted to professional researchers and misinformation will abound.

References:
Hutson, M. (2021) 'The language machines', Nature, 591(7848), pp. 22–25. Available at: https://doi.org/10.1038/d41586-021-00530-0.

Sandra Wachter, Brent Mittelstadt, Chris Russell; Do large language models have a legal duty to tell the truth?. *R. Soc. Open Sci.* 1 August 2024; 11 (8): 240197. https://doi.org/10.1098/rsos.240197

Response:

ML_PCOM7E July 2026 » Forums » Collaborative Discussion 2: Legal and Ethical Views on ANN Applications » Initial Post

Peer Response
by John-Jon Steyn - Tuesday, 6 October 2026, 1:01 PM

Hey Sarah,

Your example of drafting instructions shows where AI can save time, provided the checks reflect how the text will be used. Before sharing those instructions, I would compare them with the actual procedure and check for missing steps, ambiguous wording and incorrect assumptions. For consequential communications, a reviewer would also need access to the relevant organisational records. The time required for verification should be included when assessing any productivity gain.

Your nurse example suggests a practical way to examine bias. An organisation could test equivalent scenarios with different gender references and record whether the model changes its descriptions of competence, authority or suitability for a role. Gallegos *et al.* (2024) discuss these comparative tests alongside interventions at different stages of model development. Their review also identifies limitations in bias measurement, so I would use several tests relevant to the intended application.

I share your concern about placing the full burden of checking on individual users. Wachter, Mittelstadt and Russell (2024) argue that providers should bear responsibility for reducing misleading outputs. In an organisational setting, I would support this through approved uses, accessible source material and a process for recording and correcting recurring errors.

Adding conflicting material to training data would still require evaluating its quality. For factual questions, the relevant standard is the strength of the supporting evidence. Presenting an unsupported claim alongside a well-established finding could make the answer less reliable despite appearing balanced.

References

Gallegos, I.O., Rossi, R.A., Barrow, J., Tanjim, M.M., Kim, S., Dernoncourt, F., Yu, T., Zhang, R. and Ahmed, N.K. (2024) 'Bias and fairness in large language models: A survey', *Computational Linguistics*, 50(3), pp. 1097–1179. Available at: https://doi.org/10.1162/coli_a_00524 (Accessed: 6 October 2026).

Wachter, S., Mittelstadt, B. and Russell, C. (2024) 'Do large language models have a legal duty to tell the truth?', *Royal Society Open Science*, 11(8), 240197. Available at: https://doi.org/10.1098/rsos.240197 (Accessed: 6 October 2026).

Summary Post

Initially, I thought that AI writers could be useful for administrative tasks, but that we should be wary of having too much dependence on them – although I did suggest that it could potentially make great leaps forward in creative writing due to its unique experiences and lack of constraint in terms of imagination.

However, I am now fascinated by the subject of bias in the data provided to LLMs.

I had wondered if we could potentially 'train out' these biases by providing more conflicting information to LLMs, thereby forcing the AI to evaluate all data and provide a more rounded response. However, it's highly likely that such practices would 'train in' further unacceptable bias.

Zhou et all (2025) have answered this question for me when they asked whether LLMs should be WEIRD – Western, Educated, Industrialised, Rich and Democratic. They concluded that models that were not "WEIRD" were more likely to give culturally diverse responses, but that these responses may also not fit with accepted human rights.

I think that we, as consumers of LLM output, need to learn a new way of interpreting bias. We're used to people using their lived experience to influence the world, whether that's political bias, views on gender roles etc. We use our own biases to make judgement calls about authors and assume what their biases will be.

LLMs, however, have a different 'flavour' of bias. The bias of an LLM is generally based on the probability of what the next word in a sentence will be more than any cultural or political bias.

Gallegos *et al.* (2024) cite multiple examples of other papers that have been written about the bias of LLMs as well as providing great insight into this area at the same time.

I think that bias is a good thing for humans, but because we're used to receiving "black and white" answers from machines, we, as humans, have difficulty in accepting that AI does not always provide a perfect answer.

References:

Gallegos, I.O., Rossi, R.A., Barrow, J., Tanjim, M.M., Kim, S., Dernoncourt, F., Yu, T., Zhang, R. and Ahmed, N.K. (2024) 'Bias and fairness in large language models: A survey', *Computational Linguistics*, 50(3), pp. 1097–1179. Available at: https://doi.org/10.1162/coli_a_00524 (Accessed: 6 October 2026).

Zhou, K., Constantinides, M. and Quercia, D. (2025) 'Should LLMs be WEIRD? Exploring WEIRDness and human rights in large language models', *Proceedings of the AAAI/ACM Conference on AI, Ethics, and Society*, 8(3), pp. 2808–2820.